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THE KING'S LODGE

Hebrew Poetry and Psalms

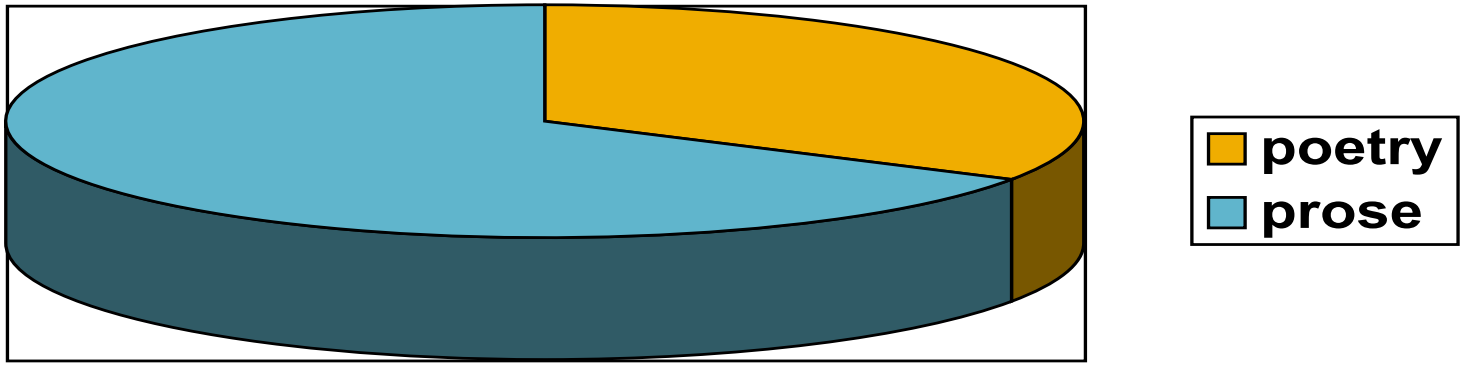
By Phil Leage

Part 2

Hebrew Poetry: Semantic Parallelism

Poetry and Prose in the Old Testament

- One third of OT is in poetic form



Books with no poetry in the Old Testament

- Leviticus
- Ruth
- Esther
- Haggai
- Malachi

Semantic Parallelism

- Bishop Robert Lowth
- 1753 distinguished three types of poetry
- “Correspondence and equality between parts of sentence”.

Semantic parallelism

- **Synonymous Parallelism**
- The second line of a poetic verse repeats the thought of the first line in different words
- Not rhyme and metre but thought rhyme
- Thought Couplet/Triplet

Synonymous Parallelism

- Continued

- Ps 19:1
- The heavens[a] are telling[b] the glory of God[c];
- and the firmament[a1] proclaims[b1] his handiwork[c1].

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Synonymous Parallelism

Psalm 114: 1-2

When Israel[a] went out from Egypt[b],

the house of Jacob[a1] from a people of strange language[b1]

Judah[a] became his sanctuary[b],

Israel[a1] his dominion[b1].

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Synonymous Parallelism

Psalm 114:3-4

The sea[a] looked and fled[b];
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The mountains[a] skipped like rams[b],
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Synonymous Parallelism

Psalm 114:3-4

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Terms used in Hebrew Poetry: Line Level

Line Level. Sometimes called a *stich,* might or might not be a complete sentence

Psalm 1

[1]Blessed is the man
who walks not in the counsel of the wicked,
nor stands in the way of sinners,
nor sits in the seat of scoffers;
[2]but his delight is in the law of the Lord,
and on his law he meditates day and night.

Terms used in Hebrew Poetry: Couplet Level

The next level of Hebrew poetry is the couplet (also called a *distich* or *bicolon*), A couplet consists of two adjacent lines related to each other by form and by content

Psalm 1

[1]Blessed is the man
who walks not in the counsel of the wicked,
nor stands in the way of sinners,
nor sits in the seat of scoffers;
[2]but his delight is in the law of the Lord,
and on his law he meditates day and night.

Terms used in Hebrew Poetry: Occasionally it is a Triplet

More rarely it is a triplet, also called a *tristich* or *tricolon*

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who walks not in the counsel of the wicked,
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nor sits in the seat of scoffers;
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and on his law he meditates day and night.

Terms used in Hebrew Poetry: Stanza

A stanza, sometimes called strophe, is a group of couplets that constitute a sense unit within a poem. It is the poetic equivalent of the paragraph

[1]Blessed is the man
who walks not in the counsel of the wicked,
nor stands in the way of sinners,
nor sits in the seat of scoffers;
[2]but his delight is in the law of the Lord,
and on his law he meditates day and night.

[3]He is like a tree
planted by streams of water
that yields its fruit in its season,
and its leaf does not wither.
In all that he does, he prospers.
[4]The wicked are not so,
but are like chaff that the wind drives away.
(Psalm 1 1-4 (ESV)

Terms used in Hebrew Poetry: Stanza

Stanzas can be recognized by features of form as well as content

[1]Blessed is the man
who walks not in the counsel of the wicked,
nor stands in the way of sinners,
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Form of Hebrew Poetry

- Hebrew poetry is governed by a basic balance between the lines of a couplet (or triplet)
- Each line has the same number of word units

Form of Hebrew Poetry

- Most couplets have three major stressed word units in each line resulting in a 3 + 3 pattern

Form of Hebrew Poetry

- In the following example, note that it often takes multiple English words to translate one Hebrew word

Form of Hebrew Poetry

- Psalm 3:2
- Yahweh, how-many-are my-foes!
- 1 + 1 + 1 = 3

- Multitudes are-rising-up against-me.
- 1 + 1 + 1 = 3

Form of Hebrew Poetry

An English Example would be:

- Ps 19:1
- The heavens[a] are telling[b] the glory of God[c];
- and the firmament[a1] proclaims[b1] his handiwork[c].

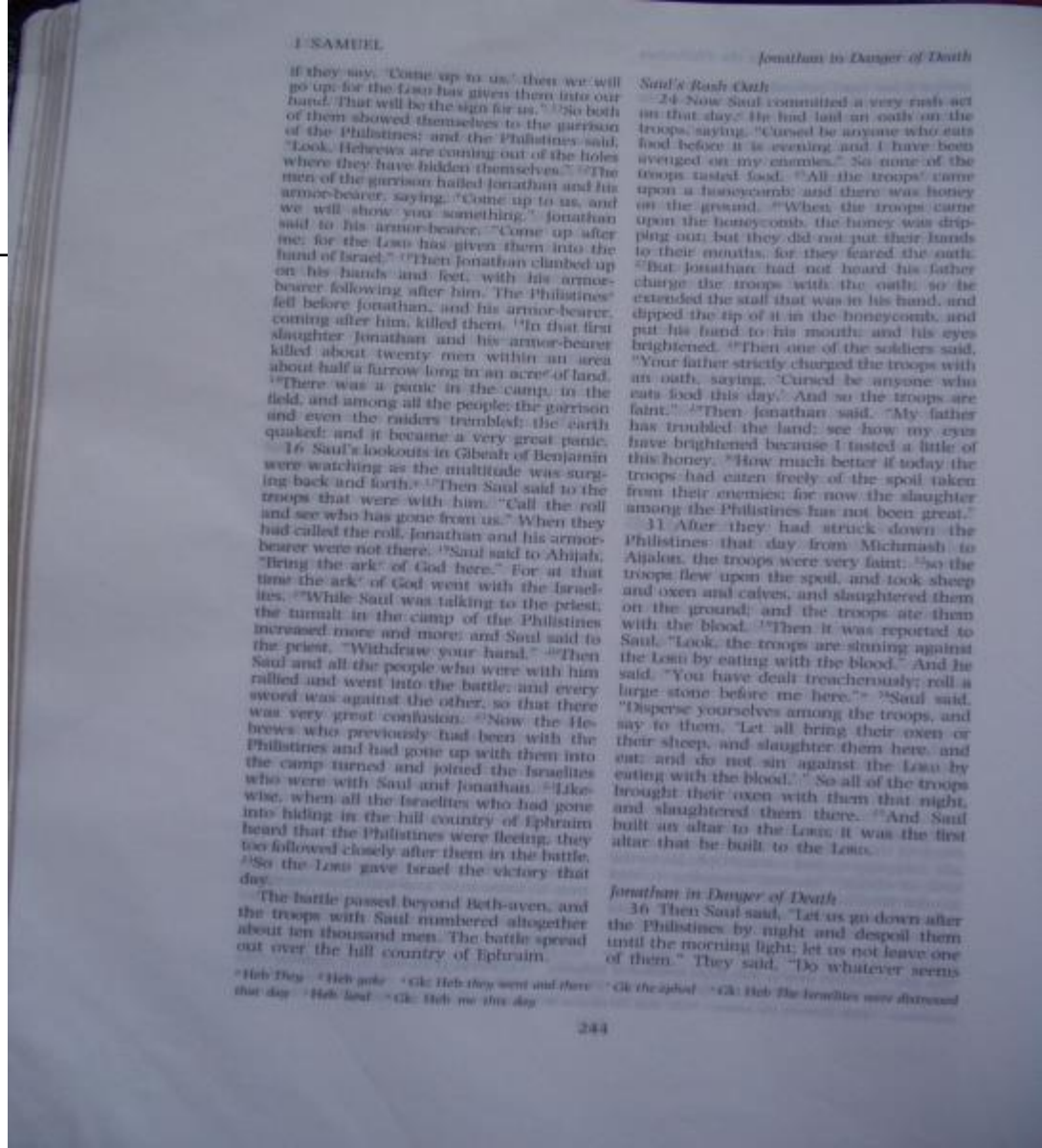
Form of Hebrew Poetry

- Some couplets have unbalanced lines of 3 + 2 word units
- This is called lament meter
- It dominates the book of Lamentations
- It is frequently found elsewhere

Formatting for Poetry

How some Bibles format the type of semantic parallelism

Formatting of Prose



1 SAMUEL

if they say, 'Come up to us,' then we will
go up; for the LORD has given them into our
hand. That will be the sign for us."[12]So both
of them showed themselves to the garrison
of the Philistines; and the Philistines said,
"Look, Hebrews are coming out of the holes
where they have hidden themselves."[13]The
men of the garrison hailed Jonathan and his
armor-bearer, saying, "Come up to us, and
we will show you something." Jonathan
said to his armor-bearer, "Come up after
me; for the LORD has given them into the
hand of Israel."[14]Then Jonathan climbed up
on his hands and feet, with his armor-
bearer following after him. The Philistines[a]
fell before Jonathan, and his armor-bearer,
coming after him, killed them.[15]In that first
slaughter Jonathan and his armor-bearer
killed about twenty men within an area
about half a furrow long in an acre[c] of land.
[16]There was a panic in the camp, in the
field, and among all the people; the garrison
and even the raiders trembled; the earth
quaked; and it became a very great panic.

14 Saul's lookouts in Gibeah of Benjamin
were watching as the multitude was surg-
ing back and forth.[17]Then Saul said to the
troops that were with him, "Call the roll
and see who has gone from us." When they
had called the roll, Jonathan and his armor-
bearer were not there.[18]Saul said to Ahijah,
"Bring the ark[d] of God here." For at that
time the ark[d] of God went with the Israel-
ites.[19]While Saul was talking to the priest,
the tumult in the camp of the Philistines
increased more and more; and Saul said to
the priest, "Withdraw your hand."[20]Then
Saul and all the people who were with him
rallied and went into the battle; and every
sword was against the other, so that there
was very great confusion.[21]Now the He-
brews who previously had been with the
Philistines and had gone up with them into
the camp turned and joined the Israelites
who were with Saul and Jonathan.[22]Like-
wise, when all the Israelites who had gone
into hiding in the hill country of Ephraim
heard that the Philistines were fleeing, they
too followed closely after them in the battle.
[23]So the LORD gave Israel the victory that
day.

The battle passed beyond Beth-aven, and
the troops with Saul numbered altogether
about ten thousand men. The battle spread
out over the hill country of Ephraim.

[a] Heb They [b] Heb gake [c] Gk: Heb they went and there
that day [d] Heb land [e] Gk: Heb me this day

Jonathan in Danger of Death

Saul's Rash Oath

24 Now Saul committed a very rash act
on that day.[e] He had laid an oath on the
troops, saying, "Cursed be anyone who eats
food before it is evening and I have been
avenged on my enemies." So none of the
troops tasted food.[25]All the troops[f] came
upon a honeycomb; and there was honey
on the ground.[26]When the troops came
upon the honeycomb, the honey was drip-
ping out; but they did not put their hands
to their mouths, for they feared the oath.
[27]But Jonathan had not heard his father
charge the troops with the oath; so he
extended the staff that was in his hand, and
dipped the tip of it in the honeycomb, and
put his hand to his mouth; and his eyes
brightened.[28]Then one of the soldiers said,
"Your father strictly charged the troops with
an oath, saying, 'Cursed be anyone who
eats food this day.' And so the troops are
faint."[29]Then Jonathan said, "My father
has troubled the land; see how my eyes
have brightened because I tasted a little of
this honey.[30]How much better if today the
troops had eaten freely of the spoil taken
from their enemies; for now the slaughter
among the Philistines has not been great."

31 After they had struck down the
Philistines that day from Michmash to
Aijalon, the troops were very faint;[32]so the
troops flew upon the spoil, and took sheep
and oxen and calves, and slaughtered them
on the ground; and the troops ate them
with the blood.[33]Then it was reported to
Saul, "Look, the troops are sinning against
the LORD by eating with the blood." And he
said, "You have dealt treacherously; roll a
large stone before me here."[34]Saul said,
"Disperse yourselves among the troops, and
say to them, 'Let all bring their oxen or
their sheep, and slaughter them here, and
eat; and do not sin against the LORD by
eating with the blood.'" So all of the troops
brought their oxen with them that night,
and slaughtered them there.[35]And Saul
built an altar to the LORD; it was the first
altar that he built to the LORD.

Jonathan in Danger of Death

36 Then Saul said, "Let us go down after
the Philistines by night and despoil them
until the morning light; let us not leave one
of them." They said, "Do whatever seems

[e] Gk the ephod [f] Gk: Heb The Israelites were distressed

Formatting of Prose

of the Philistines; and the Philistines said,
"Look, Hebrews are coming out of the holes
where they have hidden themselves." 12The
men of the garrison hailed Jonathan and his
armor-bearer, saying, "Come up to us, and
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to their mou
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put his hand
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"Your father
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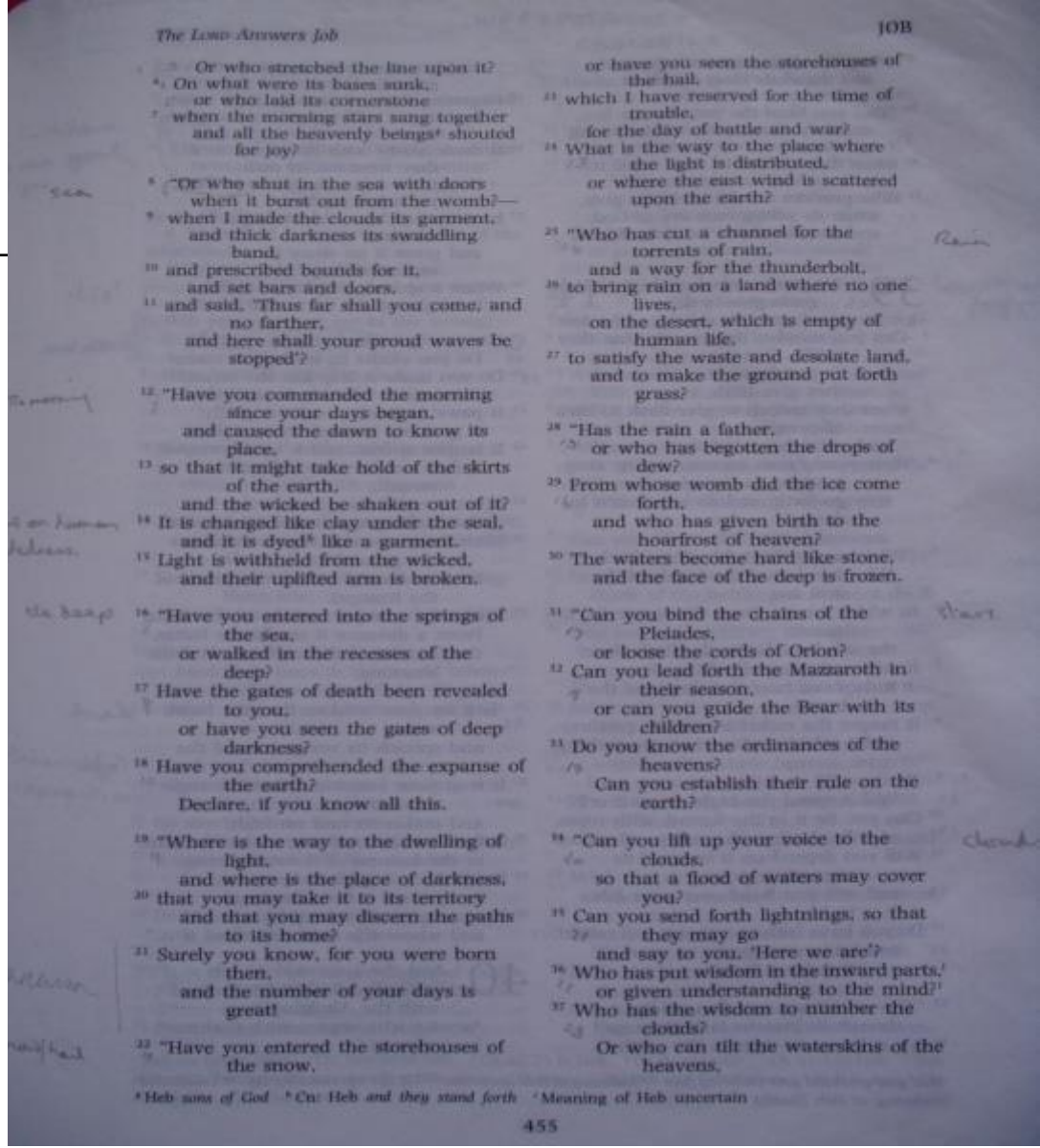
Formatting of Poetry



Or who stretched the line upon it?
6 On what were its bases sunk,
or who laid its cornerstone
7 when the morning stars sang together
and all the heavenly beings[a] shouted
for joy?

8 "Or who shut in the sea with doors
when it burst out from the womb?—
9 when I made the clouds its garment,
and thick darkness its swaddling
band,
10 and prescribed bounds for it,
and set bars and doors,
11 and said, 'Thus far shall you come, and
no farther,
and here shall your proud waves be
stopped'?

12 "Have you commanded the morning
since your days began,
and caused the dawn to know its
place,
13 so that it might take hold of the skirts
of the earth,
and the wicked be shaken out of it?
14 It is changed like clay under the seal,
and it is dyed[b] like a garment.
15 Light is withheld from the wicked,
and their uplifted arm is broken.

16 "Have you entered into the springs of
the sea,
or walked in the recesses of the
deep?
17 Have the gates of death been revealed
to you,
or have you seen the gates of deep
darkness?
18 Have you comprehended the expanse of
the earth?
Declare, if you know all this.

19 "Where is the way to the dwelling of
light,
and where is the place of darkness,
20 that you may take it to its territory
and that you may discern the paths
to its home?
21 Surely you know, for you were born
then,
and the number of your days is
great!

22 "Have you entered the storehouses of
the snow,
or have you seen the storehouses of
the hail,
23 which I have reserved for the time of
trouble,
for the day of battle and war?
24 What is the way to the place where
the light is distributed,
or where the east wind is scattered
upon the earth?

25 "Who has cut a channel for the
torrents of rain,
and a way for the thunderbolt,
26 to bring rain on a land where no one
lives,
on the desert, which is empty of
human life,
27 to satisfy the waste and desolate land,
and to make the ground put forth
grass?

28 "Has the rain a father,
or who has begotten the drops of
dew?
29 From whose womb did the ice come
forth,
and who has given birth to the
hoarfrost of heaven?
30 The waters become hard like stone,
and the face of the deep is frozen.

31 "Can you bind the chains of the
Pleiades,
or loose the cords of Orion?
32 Can you lead forth the Mazzaroth in
their season,
or can you guide the Bear with its
children?
33 Do you know the ordinances of the
heavens?
Can you establish their rule on the
earth?

34 "Can you lift up your voice to the
clouds,
so that a flood of waters may cover
you?
35 Can you send forth lightnings, so that
they may go
and say to you, 'Here we are'?
36 Who has put wisdom in the inward parts,[c]
or given understanding to the mind?[c]
37 Who has the wisdom to number the
clouds?
Or who can tilt the waterskins of the
heavens,

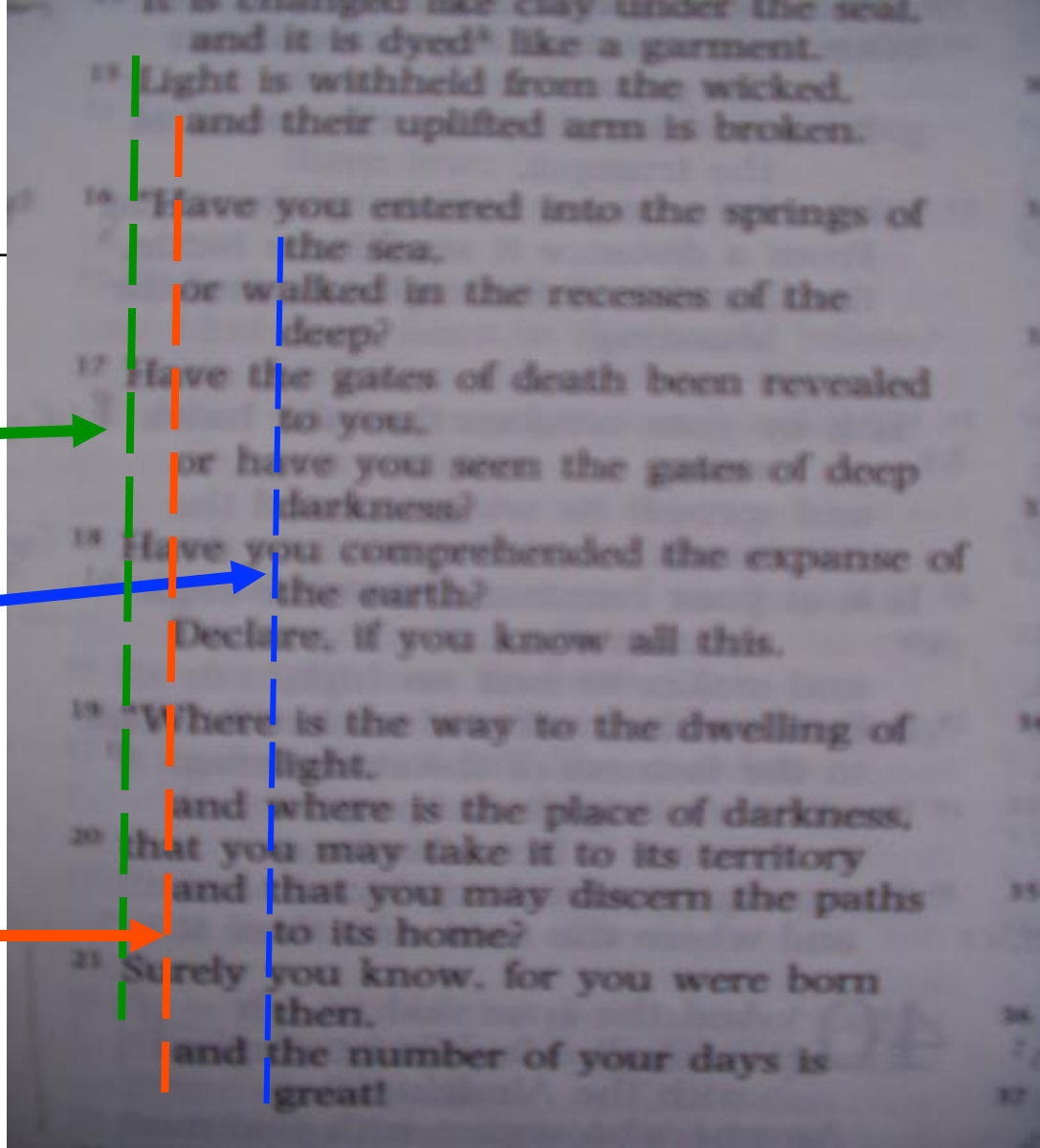
[a] Heb sons of God [b] Cn: Heb and they stand forth [c] Meaning of Heb uncertain

Formatting of Poetry

First line of poetic verse against the margin

Continuation of first line indented twice

Second line of poetic verse indented once



Antithetic Parallelism

- The two portions of a verse stand in contrast
- The second line is a negative statement
- The second line often starts with "**but**"
- This is particularly common in Proverbs

Antithetic Parallelism

- Prov 15:1
- A gentle answer turns away wrath
- **<u>but</u>** a harsh word stirs up anger.

Antithetic Parallelism

- Prov 10:1
- A wise child makes a glad father,
- **<u>but</u>** a foolish child is a mother's grief.

Antithetic Parallelism

- Sometimes Antithetic and Synonymous Parallelism is combined
- Is 1:3
- The ox[a] knows its owner[b],
- and the ass[a1] its master's crib[b1];

- **<u>but</u>** Israel[c] does not know[d],
- my people[c1] do not understand[d1].

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- The corresponding terms do not line up neatly

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- The two lines have a formal relationship defined by rhythm or line length
- but the first line is semantically continued in the second or third line

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- The couplet contains only one complete sentence, not two parallel sentences, as in the other types of parallelism

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- The two lines are parallel in form but not in content
- i.e. the 3 + 3 or the 3 + 2 form

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- Ps 51:13
- Then I will teach transgressors your ways,
- and sinners will return to you.

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- Ps 23:5
- You prepare a table before me
- In the presence of my enemies.

Synthetic or Formal Parallelism

- Ps 103:13
- As a father pities his children,
- So the Lord pities those who fear him.

The Art of Parallelism

- Balance/Symmetry
- Increases the impact of a statement
- Freedom within a form
- Viewed from different angles

The Art of Parallelism

- Continued
- Not monotonous
- Meditation is a key
- 2 points together say more than each individually